

Hatshepsut

Location: The Main Exhibition Galleries and The Grand Staircase

Hatshepsut was the sixth pharaoh of the Eighteenth Dynasty of Egypt, ruling first as regent and then as queen regnant from c. 1479 BC until c. 1458 BC. She was the Great Royal Wife of Pharaoh Thutmose II and was Egypt's second confirmed woman who ruled in her own right, following Sobekneferu in the Twelfth Dynasty.

Hatshepsut was born between 1505 and 1495 BC as the eldest daughter of Pharaoh Thutmose I and his Great Royal Wife, Ahmose. Around the age of fourteen or fifteen, she was married to her half-brother Thutmose II, who was of a similar age. Together, the couple had at least one daughter, Princess Neferure, who bore the title of King's Eldest Daughter, suggesting they may have had a second daughter who died in childhood.

Upon the death of Thutmose II, the underage Thutmose III inherited the throne at the age of two. Hatshepsut initially served as regent for her stepson from his accession in c. 1479 BC. However, by Year 7 of his reign (c. 1472 BC), she assumed the position of pharaoh and adopted the full royal titulary, becoming co-ruler alongside Thutmose III. She shared his existing regnal count, back-dating her official accession as pharaoh to Year 1. In this coregency, Thutmose III served as junior coregent while Hatshepsut held the position of senior coregent.

Ancient historical accounts state that her rule lasted for about 21 to 22 years, covering both her regency and her time as queen regnant. Josephus recorded her reign as lasting 21 years and 9 months, while Julius Africanus rounded it to 22 years. The earliest archaeological evidence acknowledging her status as pharaoh comes from grave goods dated to Year 7. She was confirmed as pharaoh by Year 9 during the Punt expedition (c. 1471 BC), and her last dated record as pharaoh appears in Year 20 (c. 1460 BC). She no longer appears in contemporary records by Year 22 (c. 1458 BC), when Thutmose III undertook his first major foreign campaign, signaling the probable year of her death.

To establish her authority within the patriarchal structure of Ancient Egypt, Hatshepsut adopted traditionally male pharaonic roles and regalia. She was depicted wearing the Khat headcloth with the uraeus, the shendyt kilt, and the traditional false beard. Her monuments portrayed her with masculine physical traits and symbolic regalia, including ram's horns and lion-form sphinxes, to present herself as both a mother and father figure to the realm. To reinforce her legitimacy, priests promoted a narrative of her divine birth, asserting that she was conceived by her mother Ahmose and the god Amun, with the gods Khnum and Heket forming her body and life force. She also cited an Oracle of Amun declaring her pharaoh and inscribed claims on her mortuary temple that her father, Thutmose I, had appointed her as his designated successor.

Breaking with the traditional custom of celebrating a royal Heb Sed jubilee after 30 years on the throne, Hatshepsut celebrated her first jubilee in Year 15 of her rule as pharaoh. Scholars suggest this may have marked 30 years since the death of her father Thutmose I, 30 years since the founding of her father's dynasty, or the 30th year of her own life.

Hatshepsut's reign was characterized by peace, economic prosperity, and extensive trade. She restored trade networks disrupted during the Hyksos occupation and funded a major naval expedition to the Land of Punt in c. 1471 BC. Her delegation returned with 31 live myrrh trees, luxury items, and frankincense, which she ground into kohl eyeliner in the first recorded use of the resin. She also sent raiding expeditions to Byblos and the Sinai Peninsula and may have led military campaigns into Nubia and Canaan.

As one of Ancient Egypt's most prolific builders, Hatshepsut commissioned hundreds of construction projects across Upper and Lower Egypt, employing the architect Ineni, the royal steward Senenmut, and High Priest Hapuseneb. Her major building accomplishments include:

- **Deir el-Bahari:** Her mortuary temple complex located opposite Luxor, featuring the Djoser-Djeseru (Holy of Holies) and reliefs commemorating her divine birth and the Punt expedition.
- **Karnak Temple Complex:** Construction of the Red Chapel (Chapelle Rouge) as a barque shrine, the restoration of the Precinct of Mut, and the erection of twin obelisks at the temple entrance. She ordered two additional obelisks in Year 16; one cracked during quarrying and remains at Aswan as the Unfinished Obelisk.
- **Speos Artemidos (Beni Hasan):** A rock-cut cavernous temple dedicated to the lioness war goddess Pakhet, featuring a famous architrave inscription denouncing the Hyksos.

Death, Burial, and Mummification of Hatshepsut

Timeline of Death & Accession

- **Last Known Record as Pharaoh:** Year 20, III Peret, Day 2 (c. May 22, 1459 BC).
- **Estimated Date of Death:** Year 22, II Peret, Day 10 (c. January 16, 1458 BC or January 1457 BC), marking the start of Thutmose III's sole reign.
- **Reign Duration:** Manetho records her total reign at 21 years and 9 months, consistent with her accession date on I Shemu, Day 4 and her death in Year 22.

Tombs and Interments

- **First Tomb:** Construction began while she was Great Royal Wife to Thutmose II, but was abandoned as it was undersized for a pharaoh.
- **Valley of the Kings (KV20):**
 - Originally quarried for her father, Thutmose I, KV20 was extended with a new burial chamber to accommodate a double interment for both Hatshepsut and her father.
 - She was initially interred here alongside Thutmose I upon her death.
- **Relocation of Mummies:**
 - During the reign of Thutmose III, a new tomb (KV38) was built, and Thutmose I was reburied there.
 - Hatshepsut's mummy may have been relocated around the same time to KV60, the tomb of her nurse, Sitre In.

- These reburials may have been orchestrated by Amenhotep II to reinforce his own claim to the throne.

Funerary Artifacts & Grave Goods

- **KV20 Discoveries:** Cleared by Howard Carter in 1903; yielded her quartz sarcophagus.
- **Other Associated Artifacts:**
 - A lioness throne (or bedstead).
 - A *senet* game board with red-jasper, lioness-headed pieces bearing her pharaonic title.
 - A signet ring and a partial shabti figurine.
 - A wooden canopic box with an ivory knob bearing her name (found in the DB320 cache), containing a mummified organ (liver or spleen) and a molar tooth.

Following her death in Year 22 of Thutmose III's reign, an attempt was made late in his reign and into the rule of his son Amenhotep II to erase Hatshepsut from official historical records. Her statues were destroyed, her monuments were defaced, and many of her architectural and administrative achievements were reassigned to other pharaohs.

Summary:

Here is a consolidated list of personal and biographical information about **Hatshepsut**, organized by her lineage, reign, claims to authority, and burial history:

Birth, Names & Titles

- **Estimated Birth Years:** c. 1505–1495 BCE.
- **Estimated Age at Death:** Approximately 47 to 50 years old (died c. 1458 BCE).
- **Name Meaning:** *H't-špswt* ("Foremost of Noble Ladies").
- **Throne Name:** **Maatkare** ("Truth/Order is the Soul of Re").
- **Extended Name:** **Khnumetamun Hatshepsut** ("Joined with Amun, Foremost of Noble Ladies").
- **Royal & Sacred Titles:**
 - King of Upper and Lower Egypt
 - Great Royal Wife
 - God's Wife of Amun
 - Lady of the Two Lands
 - Lord of Khaket

Family & Lineage

- **Parents:**
 - **Father:** Pharaoh **Thutmose I**
 - **Mother:** Great Royal Wife **Ahmose**

- **Husband:** Pharaoh **Thutmose II** (her half-brother, whom she married around age 14 or 15).
- **Children:**
 - **Princess Neferure:** Daughter who held the title "King's Eldest Daughter."
 - **Possible Second Daughter:** Likely died in childhood.
- **Stepson / Coregent:** Pharaoh **Thutmose III** (son of Thutmose II and secondary wife Iset).

Status, Political Role & Career

- **Historical Precedence:** Egypt's second confirmed female ruler in her own right (following Sobekneferu of the Twelfth Dynasty), but the first female pharaoh to rule during an era of peace and great economic prosperity.
- **Regency to Coregency Transition:**
 - Started as regent for the two-year-old Thutmose III in c. 1479 BCE upon Thutmose II's death.
 - Assumed full pharaonic power around Year 7 of his reign (c. 1472 BCE), crowning herself senior coregent (Osiris) while placing Thutmose III as junior coregent (Horus).
- **Pharaonic Regalia & Presentation:** Adopted traditional male pharaonic symbols—including the *Khat* headcloth with uraeus, *shendyt* kilt, and false beard—to establish her authority within the Egyptian patriarchy.
- **Divine Legitimacy Claims:**
 - Commissioned reliefs portraying a divine birth narrative, claiming the god Amun disguised himself as Thutmose I to father her.
 - Inscribed claims on her mortuary temple that Thutmose I had publicly designated her as his intended heir.
- **Irregular Jubilee:** Celebrated her first *Heb Sed* jubilee in Year 15 of her reign rather than waiting for the traditional 30-year mark.
- **Prolific Builder & Trader:** Re-established foreign trade networks (notably the expedition to the **Land of Punt** in c. 1471 BCE) and built major architectural works, including her mortuary temple at **Deir el-Bahari** (*Djeser-Djeseru*), twin obelisks at Karnak, and the rock-cut temple **Speos Artemidos**.

Death, Burial & Erasure

- **Date of Death:** Year 22, II Peret, Day 10 (c. January 1458 BCE or 1457 BCE), after reigning for 21 years and 9 months.
- **Burial Locations:**
 - **Cliff Tomb:** Abandoned during her regency because it was too small for a ruling pharaoh.
 - **KV20 (Valley of the Kings):** Extended her father's tomb to create a double interment chamber for both herself and Thutmose I.
 - **KV60:** Her body was likely relocated here during the reign of Thutmose III into the tomb of her nurse, Sitre In.

- **Posthumous Erasure (*Damnatio Memoriae*):** Toward the end of Thutmose III's reign and continuing under his son Amenhotep II, an official campaign was launched to erase her from history—destroying her statues, chiseling out her name from cartouches, and reassigning her monuments to other pharaohs.